

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Sales and Business Development English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For account executives, business-development representatives, sales managers, partnership teams, solutions consultants, channel managers, and revenue leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

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Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Qualification call

02 Solution fit

03 Competitive objection

04 Discount approval

05 Buying committee

06 Contract redlines

07 Channel partnership

08 Pipeline hygiene

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Qualification call

A sales team clarifies an opportunity.

Roles: Account executive / Sales development representative

Account executive: What business problem did the prospect describe, beyond wanting a demo?

Sales development representative: Their team spends hours reconciling service records. We haven't confirmed the scale or buying process.

Account executive: Then let's discover the workflow, impact, decision makers, and timing before calling it qualified.

Sales development representative: I'll arrange a discussion with the operations owner.

Account executive: Ask about the current solution and what a successful change would look like.

Sales development representative: I'll update the opportunity record with confirmed facts and clearly mark the unknowns.

Notice the professional language

buying process - The steps an organization follows to evaluate, approve, and make a purchase.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Solution fit

An account executive asks a solutions consultant about a requirement.

Roles: Account executive / Solutions consultant

Account executive: The prospect needs offline access. Can we say the product supports it?

Solutions consultant: Only for certain functions. We need their actual use case before making that statement.

Account executive: They want to capture records where connectivity is unreliable.

Solutions consultant: I'll demonstrate the supported workflow and explain synchronization limits.

Account executive: We'll document any gap instead of implying the full product works offline.

Solutions consultant: Good. Then the customer can assess fit using an accurate demonstration.

Notice the professional language

use case - A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Competitive objection

A sales team prepares for a price comparison.

Roles: Account executive / Sales manager

Account executive: The competitor is cheaper. Should I say their support is unreliable?

Sales manager: Only discuss claims we can substantiate. Ask what the customer is comparing and what matters in the decision.

Account executive: Their quote may cover fewer users and a different service level.

Sales manager: Then compare the actual scope and total cost clearly.

Account executive: I'll ask permission to review the requirements side by side.

Sales manager: Focus on our verified value and limitations rather than speculate about another supplier.

Notice the professional language

total cost - The combined costs included in a defined comparison, with assumptions stated.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Discount approval

An account executive seeks an exception.

Roles: Account executive / Sales director

Account executive: The customer asked for a fifteen-percent discount in return for a longer term.

Sales director: What's the complete commercial package, including payment, volume, and cancellation conditions?

Account executive: Those details are still being negotiated. I haven't promised the discount.

Sales director: Good. Submit the proposed terms through the approval process with the rationale and margin effect.

Account executive: I'll compare alternatives, including a smaller scope.

Sales director: Once the authorized terms are clear, you can make a proposal that accurately reflects them.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What's the complete commercial package, including payment, volume, and cancellation conditions?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Buying committee

A deal team discovers an unengaged stakeholder.

Roles: Account executive / Solutions consultant

Account executive: Our sponsor likes the proposal, but security hasn't reviewed it.

Solutions consultant: Then sponsor support isn't the same as buying approval. Who else is part of the decision?

Account executive: Procurement and the finance owner. I'll ask the sponsor to map the review sequence.

Solutions consultant: I can prepare the technical evidence through the approved customer process.

Account executive: We'll align the plan with their actual decision steps.

Solutions consultant: And keep the close date provisional until those dependencies have credible dates and owners.

Notice the professional language

close date - The expected date on which a sales transaction will be completed.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Contract redlines

Sales coordinates a proposed contract change.

Roles: Account executive / Contracts counsel

Account executive: The customer removed the liability cap. Can I accept that to keep the deal moving?

Contracts counsel: That requires legal and commercial review under our approval process.

Account executive: I'll explain their concern and the negotiation context rather than change the clause myself.

Contracts counsel: Please provide the redline and current version so we review the actual wording.

Account executive: What can I tell the customer now?

Contracts counsel: Say we're reviewing the request and will respond with authorized terms, without implying acceptance.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The customer removed the liability cap. Can I accept that to keep the deal moving?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Channel partnership

Two business-development colleagues evaluate a reseller.

Roles: Partnerships manager / Channel operations lead

Partnerships manager: The reseller wants exclusivity in a region. What would we need to evaluate?

Channel operations lead: Territory, term, performance expectations, support responsibilities, and the applicable contractual constraints.

Partnerships manager: Their projected pipeline looks promising, but no end-customer orders are confirmed.

Channel operations lead: Treat it as a forecast. We should assess capability and alternatives before granting exclusivity.

Partnerships manager: I'll develop a nonexclusive pilot option for discussion.

Channel operations lead: I'll map onboarding and operational requirements so any proposal has a workable delivery model.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The reseller wants exclusivity in a region. What would we need to evaluate?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Pipeline hygiene

A sales manager reviews an optimistic forecast.

Roles: Sales manager / Account executive

Sales manager: This deal is marked committed. What evidence supports that stage?

Account executive: The sponsor said they intend to proceed, but procurement and budget approval are still open.

Sales manager: Then update the forecast to match the actual stage criteria.

Account executive: I'll record the remaining decisions and the customer's next agreed step.

Sales manager: Keep the opportunity value and close date separate from confidence in completion.

Account executive: I'll revise the record today so the forecast reflects the evidence rather than my preferred outcome.

Notice the professional language

close date - The expected date on which a sales transaction will be completed.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Discovery and Qualification

SHARED CASE

A prospect asks for a demonstration but has not explained the current workflow, problem, or buying process.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What are you trying to improve in the current workflow? Could we understand the problem and who will evaluate the solution? That will help us make the demonstration relevant to your decision.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Value Proposition and Use-Case Fit

SHARED CASE

A sales slide lists product features, but the prospect wants to reduce time spent preparing monthly reports.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The relevant question is how the product supports your reporting workflow. I'll connect the demonstration to that task and show what would need to be tested before we claim a time saving.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Objection Handling and Competitive Pressure

SHARED CASE

A prospect says a competitor is cheaper, but the quotes include different service levels and implementation support.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we compare the same scope and support assumptions? The quoted prices cover different packages. That will help us discuss total cost and fit without dismissing the other option.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Pricing, Discounting, and Approval

SHARED CASE

A customer requests a 15% discount. The salesperson can discuss options but does not have authority to approve that reduction.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

I can take the request through our approval process. Could we clarify the scope and commercial terms you are proposing? I do not want to promise a discount before it is authorized.

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Enterprise Buying Committees

SHARED CASE

A contact is enthusiastic about a proposal but has not explained who controls the budget or approves the purchase.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Who else needs to evaluate the proposal, and how is the budget approved? I'd like to understand the decision process so we can provide the right information to each participant.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Negotiation and Contract Redlines

SHARED CASE

A customer returns contract wording on liability and asks the salesperson to accept it immediately.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'll send the proposed wording to the appropriate legal and commercial reviewers. Could you explain the business concern behind the change so they can assess it in context?

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Partnerships and Channel Development

SHARED CASE

A potential channel partner requests exclusivity but has not specified territory, activities, or expected contribution.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we define the territory, responsibilities, and expected contribution first? Those details are necessary for the team to evaluate whether an exclusive arrangement would make sense.

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

CRM Hygiene and Pipeline Reviews

SHARED CASE

A deal is forecast to close this month, but procurement has not started and the customer has given no confirmed date.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The current close date is an assumption. Procurement has not started, and the customer has not confirmed timing. I'll update the forecast explanation and identify the next evidence needed.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.